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Some Unique Places

Shanti's parents seemed busier planning their summer vacation. "Are we doing something different this year?", she asked. "Maybe we could go to more places rather than staying in one place? I really want to see more of our country now that I am growing up."

Appa (father) and Amma (mother) smiled, "Shanti, your wish might just come true. We have big plans this time! A trip to a few different places starting from the southernmost tip of India!".

“From Kanyakumari?”, Shanti asked.
 “No, Shanti!”, Appa said to her surprise.



Find out

Look at the map for the southernmost point of India.

Shanti found out from the map that Indira Point is the southernmost tip of India. It is a long chain of islands known as the Andaman and Nicobar Islands.



Do you know?

An island is a land surrounded by water on all sides. There are over a thousand islands in the seas around India that are part of the country.



Find out

1. In which sea are the Andaman and Nicobar Islands located?

2. Name the other islands you know.

Islands of India

They started from Sri Vijaya Puram, the capital city of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands. Rani, their local guide, took them through the forest.

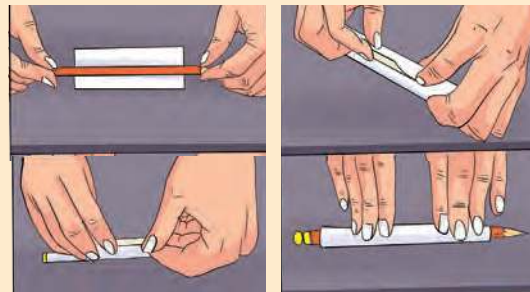


“Many of the trees are unique and found only in these islands”, Rani said. Shanti was curious about the big roots growing out of the bottom of the tree and spreading out wide, supporting the tree.

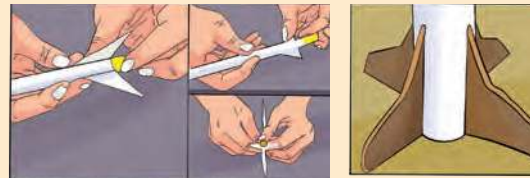


Activity 1

Take a rectangular piece of newspaper or used paper, and roll it into a thin tube. Glue the edges so it does not open. Then, make it stand it up on a flat surface. Does it stay up?



Now, cut 3-4 small triangles from thick paper. Stick the triangles evenly around the bottom of the roll. Rest the paper on a flat surface again. Does it stay upright now?



The base supports the roll like the roots support the tree to stand upright.

Nature often has the best designs.

“The forests here are home to many animals, colourful birds, butterflies and insects that are unique. Birds like the Andaman wood pigeon and the Andaman hornbill are only found here. That makes these forests very special and important for us to protect”, Rani said.





Andaman hornbill



Andaman wood pigeon

Why do you think some birds and animals are found only on these islands?

Next, they went to catch a ferry to one of the nearby islands.



Safety Measures

Before getting on the ferry, they were given safety instructions. Everyone must wear a life jacket even if you know how to swim. Life jackets keep you afloat if you fall into the water.



Write

1. Draw or write about your favourite fish or other sea animal.

The Apatani tribes in Arunachal Pradesh grow rice and fish together in the same field, using no machines or fertilisers.



2. List at least three living things found in the sea.

Rani took them to the Marine Interpretation Centre. Through pictures, models and information they learned how tiny corals give shelter to many creatures. They started to see how marine life is important not just for the sea, but for the whole Earth.



Discuss

1. Why do you think life under the sea is just as important as life in the forests?
2. How do you think the coral reef helps the fish and other sea creatures?

Before they left the island, they heard about North Sentinel Island. “Here people live like the ancient hunter-gatherers,” Rani told us. “They do not want visitors, so no one is allowed to go there”, said Rani. In 2004, a tsunami hit the region but they survived, possibly by noticing signs in nature like changes in the wind, sea and behaviour of animal. Their deep connection with nature might have helped them stay safe.



Discuss

How do you think their knowledge might have helped the people of North Sentinel Island stay safe?

Note to the Teacher

The teacher will explain corals through pictures as colourful living beings seen in the sea.



Before this trip, Shanti had only seen islands on television. Now, after visiting the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, she had learned so much. Islands are full of wonders, and they need our care and respect.

Amma said that they would be going from Sri Vijaya Puram by ship to Kolkata and from there to the Sundarbans.

“Sundarbans is a different kind of forest”, said Amma. “Something you have never seen.” she added This made Shanti so curious that she could not wait to get there.

Sundarbans: Home of the Mangroves

After a short stop in Kolkata, they reached the Sundarbans, the largest mangrove forest in the world. This forest is seen where the river Ganga meets the sea, and the land is muddy and salty. Special trees called mangroves grow in this wet and salty land.



Write

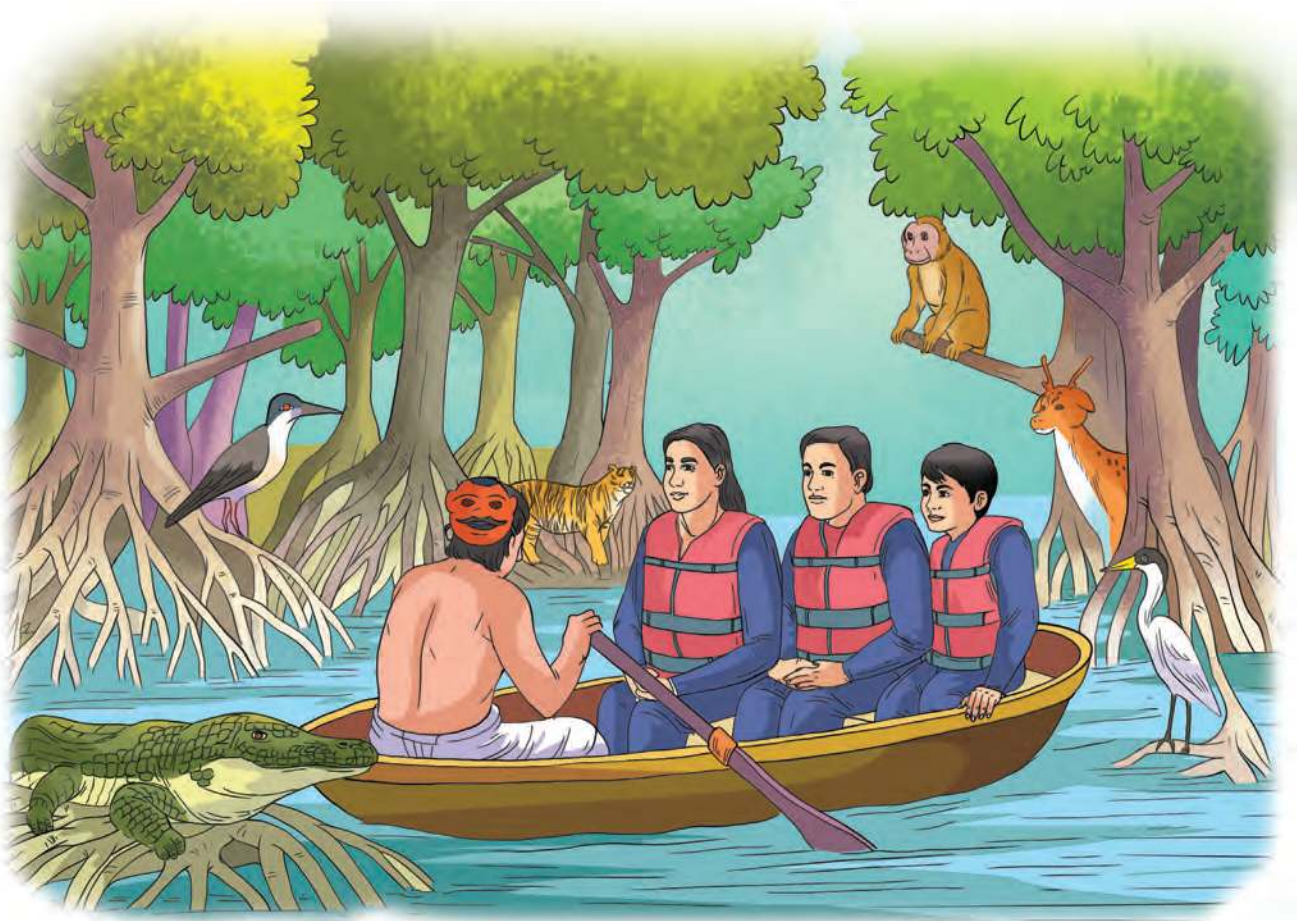
1. What do you find in the mangrove forest? List any three.

2. What do you think makes this place different from other forests?

“Appa, what are those tiny stick-like things coming out of the water?”, asked Shanti.



“Those are the roots of the mangroves which help them breathe in the muddy salt water”, he answered.



Mangroves are important because their roots hold the soil together and help stop waves from washing the land away. Many people here live close to the forest and depend on it for their daily needs. For generations, they have lived in harmony with the nature.



Write

In what ways do people in Sunderbans depend on the mangrove forests?



The Sundarbans felt like a world where land, water and wildlife all live together. Mangroves like the Sundarbans are very important to us.



Discuss

Why do you think it is important to take care of places like the Sundarbans?



Find out

Look around yourself. Do you see any living thing that has something special to help it live there? What is it?

“Why would someone wear a mask on the back of their head?”, Shanti asked curiously.

Appa told, “I heard that it has something to do with how tigers attack their prey from behind. Tigers may get confused by the masks”.

Northeast India: Green Hills and Great Traditions

After leaving the Sundarbans, Shanti and her family began their journey towards the Northeast of India.

“Did you know that the seven states called the ‘Seven Sisters’, along with the state of Sikkim, makes up what we call the Northeast India?”, Appa asked. “Oh, yes! I remember this from class”, Shanti replied excitedly.

Can you name the seven Northeastern states?





Write

1. Look at the picture. Identify three things being sold in the market.

2. Identify the festival from the above picture.

3. Why do you think the houses are built on bamboo structures?

4. What animals do you see in the picture?

5. What does this picture tell you about the people who live with nature in the Northeast of India?



The Northeast of India is a land full of colours, creativity and life. People here live closely with nature. The region is home to lush forests, flowing rivers, and amazing animals and birds. From weaving and crafts to music, dance and festivals—every part of life is connected to the hills, forests and wildlife around them. It is a place where culture and nature grow together.



Do you know?

Bhut Jolokia or ghost pepper is one of the hottest chillies in the world. It grows in the Northeast India and is used in pickles, chutneys, and even to keep elephants away from the crops.



“What are they doing?”, Shanti asked.

“They are helping protect the *Hargila* bird, the Greater Adjutant Stork”, said Amma. “The women are teaching the children to help protect their nests.”



Shanti joined the group and learned how the *Hargila* birds have been growing in number with everyone's help.



Discuss

In small groups, choose an animal or bird near you that needs protection. What can you do to help? Create a protection plan and share it with the class.

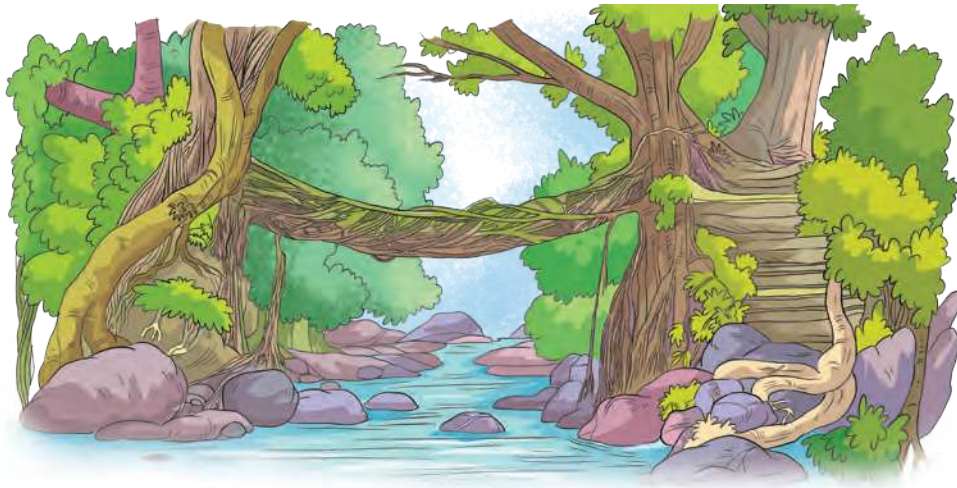


Activity 2

In small groups, collect twigs, leaves and soft materials like cotton or paper available around you.

Create a small bird's nest using the materials. What makes a good nest? What does the nest need to keep the eggs safe?

“What are they? How are these made?”, Shanti asked their new guide, Chandan.



“Those are the living root bridges. The roots of these trees across the streams became strong enough to walk on. We just have to look after them now”, said Chandan.





Activity 3

Try a 'Root bridge challenge' in class. Can you connect two chairs using string or sticks in a way that will hold a small toy?

As they explored the islands and the Northeast, they saw many amazing plants and animals. "Appa, what makes these places so special?", Shanti asked.

Appa smiled and said, "Many of the plants and animals found here are not found anywhere else in the world! That's what makes this one of nature's special places—a kind of nature's hotspot. Now, I'll take you to another hotspot in our country".

"Do you remember reading about the Indian Giant Squirrel in Grade 4? It is also found in the Western Ghats where we are going next."

Western Ghats

Appa said, "We are now heading to another mountain range, the Western Ghats, a long chain of forested hills known for its rich plant and animal life".



Write

1. Look at the map, locate the Western Ghats and name the six states it passes through.

2. What animals can you spot in the forest?

Note to the Teacher

The teacher will show the Western Ghats in the physical map of India.

Kumbhalgarh Fort in Rajasthan, which boasts the second longest continuous wall in the world, is stretched over 36 kilometres.



- What are the people doing in the picture given below?

- Why do you think forts were built on hilltops instead of flat land?



“The lion-tailed macaques are only found here”, Appa told. Like in the islands, some animals and birds are found only in this region.

“Do you know that several rivers of India begin from these hills?”, said Appa.



Write

Give the names of three rivers that start from the Western Ghats.



These hills have many plants that are used in traditional medicine. Many of these plants grow only in this region. Many tribal communities and other forest-dwelling people have lived here for generations. They depend on the forest and its plants for food, medicine and their livelihood.

Just then, Shanti saw a group of students with notebooks and cameras under a tree. “What are they doing?”, she asked.

“These students are part of a survey. With help from schools, farmers and experts, we found and recorded over 200 types of mangoes in the Western Ghats! Now, we are also looking at jackfruit and *jamun*”, explained Satish, a researcher who was guiding the students.

Shanti was amazed.

“Can I do something like this for the trees and fruits in my place too?”, she wondered.



Activity 4

Pick a fruit or vegetable that grows in your state. It may have varieties. With the help of your teacher or elders make a list of how many types and varieties of fruits and vegetables are locally known.

The journey through the Western Ghats was coming to an end, but Shanti's mind was full of questions and ideas.



Appa said, “Let me also tell you about the Silent Valley National Park. It is a wonderful rainforest in Kerala, home to many rare plants and animals. Unlike other rainforests, which receive a lot of rain and are usually buzzing with the sound of cicada insects; this rainforest was silent giving the valley its name”.

Appa continued, “Long ago, a dam was planned here, which would have flooded this special forest. But people from all over—villagers, students, scientists—joined together in the ‘Save Silent Valley Movement’. Their love for nature helped stop the dam. Today, the Silent Valley remains a protected forest, showing how people can save forests when they care enough to act together”.

Our hills are full of life, stories and surprises. From tiny herbs to great rivers, and from rare animals to the people—everything is connected. We need to understand and protect these places, and their connections.



Do you know?

Protected areas are special places like forests, rivers or hills that are kept safe by the government to protect animals, plants and nature. People are not allowed to cut trees or harm animals in these areas. The Western Ghats have over 50 protected areas such as, wildlife sanctuaries, national parks and tiger reserves. These help protect rare animals like the lion-tailed macaque, tiger, elephant and hornbill, and keep the forests and rivers healthy.





Write

List three protected areas in the Western Ghats.

Shanti and her family had stayed in the Andaman Islands and now they were heading to Kanyakumari, the southernmost point of the Indian mainland, where three seas meet.

From coral reefs in the sea to root bridges in the hills and the spice-filled forests of the ghats, every place has something special to teach us. Each region is home to its own wildlife, trees, people and wonders of nature. People live differently in various regions, but everywhere, they depend on nature and care for it in their own way.



Their journey showed us how rich, beautiful and connected our country truly is. If we want these wonders to stay for the future, we must all do our part by learning, respecting and protecting the land we call home.

Let us reflect

1. What surprised you the most about the places visited in this journey across India? Why?
2. Which place would you like to visit the most and what would you do there?
3. How is your region similar or different from one of the places in the story?

Mawsynram in Meghalaya is the most wet inhabited place on Earth.



4. Match the following aquatic animals with their features.



- Has no brain but can regrow its arms, if lost.



- Fish that swims upright, face looks like that of a horse.



- With hard shells, return to the beach where they were born to lay eggs.



- Has eight arms and can change its colour to hide.



- Lives safely among stinging sea anemones.



- Tiny sea animals that form colourful reefs and homes for fish.



- Has a soft, transparent body and stings with its tentacles.



- Smart mammals that breathe air and live in groups.



5. What is special about mangroves?
6. How do people in different regions live in harmony with the nature?
7. Make a collage by pasting pictures depicting vibrant India.



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